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THE PROBLEM OF THEOLOGICAL METHOD

II

PAUL TILLICH*

I. METHOD AND REALITY

METHOD is the systematic way of doing something, especially of gaining knowledge. No method can be found in separation from its actual exercise; methodological considerations are abstractions from methods actually used. Descartes's *Discours de la méthode* followed Galileo's application of the method of mathematical physics and brought it to general consciousness and philosophical definiteness. Schleiermacher's method, as used in the *Glaubenslehre*, followed the mystical-romantic reinterpretation of religion and established a methodology of inner experience. The methodological remarks made in this paper describe the method actually used in my attempts to elaborate a theology of "self-transcending Realism" (*gläubiger Realismus*), which is supposed to overcome supra-naturalism as well as its naturalistic counterpart.

It is not a sound procedure to borrow a method for a special realm of inquiry from another realm in which this method has been successfully used. It seems that the emphasis on the so-called "em-

pirical" method in theology has not grown out of actual theological demands but has been imposed on theology under the pressure of a "methodological imperialism," exercised by the pattern of natural sciences. This subjection of theology to a strange pattern has resulted in an undue extension of the concept "empirical" and the lack of a clear distinction between the different meanings of "experience" in the theological enterprise. For some it is the general human experience on the basis of which they try to approach inferentially the religious objects; for others it is the religious experience of mankind, empathically interpreted. Sometimes it is the religious experience of the theologian and the group to which he belongs that gives the material for an "empirical" theology. Sometimes an ontological intuition is called "experience." Certainly, every concrete reality is open to many methods, according to its different "levels" or "functional potentialities." And each of the ways mentioned (besides some others) can contribute something to the investigation of a phenomenon as complex as religion. But the confusing term "empirical" should not be imposed on all of them; nor should the attempt be made to establish a methodological monism which includes chemistry as well as theology. Reality itself makes demands, and the method must follow; reality offers itself in different ways, and our cognitive intellect must receive it in different ways. An exclusive method applied to everything closes many ways of approach

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and impoverishes our vision of reality. A world construed according to the model of classical mechanics or Hegelian dialectics or behavioristic protocols is not the cognitive fulfilment of the potentialities of reality. In this respect a genuine pragmatism which refuses to close any door is much more realistic than a dogmatic empiricism with which it is sometimes confused—even by its own followers.

We encounter reality—or reality imposes itself upon us—sometimes in a more complex way, sometimes in definite and distinguishable elements and functions. Whenever we encounter reality in the one or the other way, it challenges our cognitive power and brings it into action. The way in which the cognitive power works is dependent on three factors: its own structure, the structure of the reality it encounters, and the relation of the two structures. In a methodical approach these three factors are noticed, analyzed, and evaluated. But the *prius* of all this is the encounter itself; and nothing is more destructive for knowledge than the establishment of methods which, by their very nature, prevent the actual encounter or prejudice its interpretation. (It is my opinion that the term “encounter” is more adequate for our pre-theoretical relation to reality than the term “experience,” which has lost so much of its specific meaning that it needs to be “saved,” namely, restricted to a theoretically interpreted encounter.)

The presupposition of theology is that there is a special encounter with reality—or a special way in which reality imposes itself on us—which is ordinarily called “religious.” And it is the presupposition of this paper that “having a religious encounter with reality” means “being ultimately concerned about reality.”

II. THEOLOGY AND PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION

The ultimate concern or the religious encounter with reality can be considered in two ways. It can be looked at as an event beside other events, to be observed and described in theoretical detachment; or it can be understood as an event in which he who considers it is “existentially” involved. In the first case the philosopher of religion is at work, in the second the theologian speaks. The philosopher of religion notices the ultimate concern, which he cannot help finding in the history of religion as a quality of practically all representative personalities, symbols, and activities that are called “religious.” But in his dealing with this characteristic of religion he himself is only theoretically, but not existentially, concerned. The religious concern is not his concern in so far as he is a philosopher of religion. He points to it, he explains it, but his work is not an expression of the religious encounter with reality. This is different in the theologian. He applies his ultimate concern to everything, as an *ultimate* concern demands—even to his theoretical interpretation of the religious encounter. For the theologian the interpretation of the ultimate concern is itself a matter of ultimate concern, a *religious* work.

But this distinction is not unambiguous. There is an element in every philosophy (not only in every philosopher) which is “existential,” i.e., which has the character of an ultimate decision about the meaning of reality. The less technical and the more creative a philosophy is, the more it shows, at least implicitly, an ultimate concern. No creative philosophy can escape its religious background. This is the reason for the tremendous influence that philosophy has had not only on theology but also on the history of re-

ligion and vice versa; for, as the philosopher cannot escape his theological background, so the theologian cannot escape his philosophical tool. Those who try to do so deceive themselves: their language, which is shaped through philosophy, betrays them (as even Barth has admitted).

Nevertheless, the distinction between theology and philosophy of religion is valid and cannot be obliterated without dangerous consequences. It is very unfortunate that the so-called "Continental" theology has brought into disregard the function of an independent philosophy of religion, thus creating an intolerable theological absolutism; and it is equally unfortunate that American (nonfundamentalistic) theology was not able to protect itself from being dissolved into a general philosophy of religion, thus producing a self-destructive relativism.

Theology is the existential and, at the same time, methodical interpretation of an ultimate concern. The interpretation of an ultimate concern is "existential" if it is done in the situation of concern. The interpretation of an ultimate concern is methodical if it relates the concern rationally to the whole of experience. Theology, literally and historically, unites these two elements. Theological propositions, therefore, are propositions which deal with an object in so far as it is related to an ultimate concern. No object is excluded from theology if this criterion is applied, not even a piece of stone; and no object is in itself a matter of theology, not even God as an object of inference. This makes theology absolutely universal, on the one hand, and absolutely definite, on the other hand. Theology has to deal with everything, but only under the theological criterion, the ultimate concern.

The concept "ultimate concern" is it-

self the result of a theological procedure. It expresses two sides of the religious experience: (1) The one side is the absolute or unconditional or ultimate element in religious experience. Every religious relation, attitude, symbol, and action is unconditionally *serious*; *decisive* in an absolute sense; *transcending* any preliminary, transitory, and dependent value. The whole history of religion confirms this side of religious experience. Where there is a living religion, it makes an absolute claim; it claims the "whole heart"; it does not admit anything ultimate besides itself. (2) The other side is the dynamic presence of the "ultimate" as a continuous, never ceasing, concrete, and universal concern, always demanding and giving, always threatening and promising. As an actual concern it expresses itself in the actualities of life, qualifying every section of existence and using every section of existence for its own embodiment in symbols and actions; for the religious or ultimate concern refers to the ultimate foundation of our being and the ultimate meaning of our existence. Therefore, we can formulate the abstract criterion of every theological work in this way: Those propositions are theological which deal with a subject in so far as it belongs to the foundation of our being and in so far as the meaning of our existence depends on it.

III. THE POSITIVE ELEMENT IN THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD

The ultimate concern is a concrete concern; otherwise it could not be a concern at all. Even mysticism lives in concrete traditions and symbols in order to express, in action and thought, that which transcends everything concrete. Theology, therefore, must interpret the totality of symbols, institutions, and ideas in which an ultimate concern has

embodied itself; theology is, first of all, *positive*. It works on the basis, in the material, and for the purpose of an actual religion. The participation in a religious reality is a presupposition of all theology. You have to be within the circle of a concrete religion in order to interpret it existentially. This is the "theological circle" which theology cannot (and never should try to) escape. This circle is not vicious, but its denial is dishonest, for it could be denied only in the name of an assumedly higher ultimate, which immediately would establish the same circle.

Traditionally, the theological circle has been expressed in the assertion that faith is the precondition of theology. (*Pistis* precedes *gnosis*, as the Alexandrians said; *credo ut intelligam*, as Anselm, following Augustine, formulated it.) Faith, in this context, means a convinced and active participation in the life of a religious group, its traditions, its tensions, its activities. It is not the individual belief of the theologian to which they refer (as we are inclined to misinterpret the *credo ut intelligam*); but it is the spiritual substance out of which a theologian must create, even if he is aware of the weakness of his personal faith (otherwise there would be no honest theologian).

The ultimate concern out of which *we* are working as theologians is embodied in Christianity. If a Christian theologian says that for him Christianity is one among other elements in the religion he intends to interpret, this can mean two things—either that he is not a theologian but a philosopher of religion or that he belongs to a new religious synthesis which is, like everything concrete, inclusive and exclusive at the same time and which therefore establishes a theological circle, just as Christianity does.

Since such a concrete synthesis has not yet appeared within my own theological circle and since I am convinced that Christianity is able to take all possible elements of religious truth into itself without ceasing to be Christianity, I am going to speak now about Christian theology, as the only one which is within my existential reach.

Christian theology is a work of the Christian church. The theological function is one of its essential functions, which never can be lost so long as there is the church. Christian theology, moreover, cannot be carried on except by the church. The positive character of the ultimate concern makes "individual theology" impossible. The individual theologian can and should find more adequate methods of interpretation. But he cannot find that which he is asked to interpret. Concretely speaking: Christian theology is the interpretation of the message that Jesus is the Christ, and of the symbols and institutions based on this message. Theology is the methodical self-interpretation of the Christian church (1) in the direction of its foundation, the "new reality" which has become manifest in Jesus as the Christ, and (2) in the direction of the life, past and present, which is determined by this new reality. The original document of the new reality is the Bible; the expression of the life determined by this new reality is the Tradition.

IV. THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD WITH RESPECT TO BIBLE AND TRADITION

Bible and Tradition give the material in which the theologian works. The Bible implies three elements which have different impacts on the theological method. First, and basically, it contains the decisive manifestation of what concerns

us ultimately, in the picture of Jesus as the Christ. This is the criterion of all Christian theology, the criterion also of the theological use of the Bible, for the Bible contains, second, the reception of this manifestation in the original church. Every biblical writer is, at the same time, a witness to the new reality in Jesus as the Christ and a witness of the way in which he and the group to which he belongs have received the new reality. In the latter sense they have started the Tradition. In the first sense they point to that which judges the Tradition, including their own contribution to it. (This is the meaning of Luther's statement that the Bible is the "Word of God" in so far as it *Christum treibet*; in the power of this criterion he himself judged the canon.) From this it follows that not the Bible as such, as a part of the history of religion, is the norm of Christian theology but the Bible in so far as it is the genuine witness to the new reality. It is the permanent task of Christian theology (in unity with the developing religious and historical understanding of the Bible) to elaborate the norm of Christian theology out of the whole of the biblical material and to apply the norm equally to Bible and Tradition. The third element in the biblical literature that is important for theological method is the preparation for the decisive manifestation of the new reality and for its reception by the church. In the Old as well as in the New Testament we find in language, rites, and ideas a large element of general revelation as it has occurred and continuously occurs within human religion generally. Our eyes have been opened to this element by the work of the *religionsgeschichtliche Schule* in historical theology. So far as method goes, this means that in every theological statement we must take into considera-

tion the religious substance which is transformed and purified in the prophetic and apostolic message. Only in this sense, but in this sense definitely, the *history of religion* belongs to the positive element in Christian theology. The universality of the Christian claim implies that there is no religion, not even the most primitive, which has not contributed or will not contribute to the preparation and reception of the new reality in history. In this sense the theologian always must be a "pagan" and a "Jew" and a "Greek" (humanist) and bring their spiritual substance under the criterion of the theological norm. For instance, the terms "Son of Man," "Messiah," "Son of God," "Kyrios," "Logos," appear in the history of religion; and, if they are used for the interpretation of the new reality, they contribute to it with their previous connotations, but in such a way that their meaning is judged and saved at the same time. This method of *judging and saving the history of religion* is exercised by all the biblical writers. It must be done methodically and creatively by the theologian.

Methodologically, the Tradition (the beginning of which is the biblical literature) is not normative but *guiding*. This is a rejection of the Roman Catholic point of view; just as the subordination of the biblical literature to the theological norm implied in it is a rejection of orthodox Protestantism. Tradition cannot be normative in Christian theology because there is always an element in Tradition which must be judged and cannot be the judge itself. But Tradition can and must be guiding for the theologian, because it is the expression of the continuous reception of the new reality in history and because, without tradition, no theological existence is possible. It is rather a naïve illusion of some Prot-

estants to believe that by jumping over two thousand years of Christian tradition they can come into a direct and existential (more than philological) relation to the biblical texts. The guiding function of the Tradition has a positive and a negative side. Positively, the Tradition shows the questions implied in the Christian message, the main possibilities of answers, and the points in which Christians have agreed and have disagreed. Negatively, the Tradition shows answers which have generally been avoided and, above all, answers which have been characterized by the church as "heretical." He who takes the Tradition seriously must take heresies seriously. He knows that a heresy is supposed to be, not a deviating opinion, but an existential attack on, or a distortion of, the theological norm in the name of theology. He will not easily—not without the consciousness that he risks his participation in the new reality—promote a view which has been characterized as heretical by the church as a whole. This, of course, should not prevent anyone from following his theological conscience (as Luther did in Worms); but it should sharpen that conscience.

The positive element in theological method is historically given. But nothing is more ambiguous than the concept "historical." When the Anglican church accepted the apostolic succession as one of its basic doctrines, it meant to emphasize the historical continuity of the manifestation of the new reality in history. In this sense the doctrine emphasized the historical element in church and theology. But when Anglican theologians, answering Roman attacks, tried to justify the apostolic character of their episcopate by an 8,000 to 1 documentary probability that there was a real apostolic succession, they introduced another

meaning of "historical," namely, the probabilities (which never can become religious certainties) of historical research. In that moment their religious position was scientifically undermined because they confused the two meanings of "historical." The same is true of biblical criticism. If the Christian faith is based even on a 100,000 to 1 probability that Jesus has said or done or suffered this or that; if Christianity is based on possible birth-registers of Nazareth or crime-registers of Pontius Pilate, then it has lost its foundation completely. Then the historical event, that a new reality has appeared in mankind and the world (a reality which is reflected in the picture of Jesus as the Christ), has become a matter of empirical verification, ideally through a competent reporter, armed with a camera, phonograph, and psychograph. Since such a reporter, unfortunately, was not available in the year A.D. 30, we have to replace him by more or less probable conjectures. But this is not the historical character of Jesus as the Christ. It is regrettable that one of the greatest events in the history of religion—the radical criticism of the holy legend of Christianity by Christian theologians, which destroyed a whole system of pious superstition—has been abused for the purpose of giving a pseudo-scientific foundation to the Christian faith. The historical foundation of theological method does not mean that the theologian has to wait, with fear and trembling, for the next mail which may bring him a new, more critical, or more conservative statement about some important facts of the "life of Jesus" according to which he has to change his faith and his theology. But it does mean that his theology is determined by the event of the appearance of the new reality in history, as reflected in

the *full* biblical picture of Jesus as the Christ and as witnessed by all biblical writers and by the whole tradition of Christianity.

V. THE ELEMENT OF IMMEDIACY IN THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD

The positive element in theology, as discussed above, gives the *content* of theological work; the rational element, to be discussed later, gives the *form* of theological work; and the element of immediacy, to be discussed now, gives the *medium* of theological work. Without participation in the reality within which theology speaks, no theology is possible; it is the air in which theology breathes. We call this participation "experience" in the larger sense of the word, in which it covers the mere encounter as well as the cognitively conscious encounter. "Experience" in both senses is the medium, the element in which theology lives. But the religious experience of the theologian is not a positive source and not a norm of systematic theology. Everybody's religious experience is shaped by the denominational group to which he belongs. The education in his own church opened the door to religious reality for every theologian. Later he has personal experiences which confirm or transform his earlier ones. But his intention should never be to make his earlier or later experiences the content of his theology; they certainly will enter into it, but this is an event, not an intention. It is the function of the medium to mediate, not to hold fast. It was the danger of Schleiermacher's theology that his concept of "religious consciousness" became confused with "experience." But it contradicts the basic principle of the Reformation to look at one's self instead of looking beyond one's self at the new reality which liberates man from

himself. Our experience is changing and fragmentary; it is not the source of truth, although without it no truth can become *our* truth.

It might be said that the whole history of religion, including the biblical religion and the development of Christianity, is the reservoir of man's religious experience and that the positive element of theology is identical with the contents of this experience. Such a statement is correct, but ambiguous. A content, e.g., of the experience of the prophet Isaiah, is the paradoxical acting of God in history. This divine acting transcends every immediate experience. It has become manifest to the prophet in a situation which we should call "revelation." Of course, the prophet is aware of this situation, and to that extent it is an "experience." Not the experiential side, however, is significant for the prophet and for the theologian, but the revelatory side. The word "revelation" has been distorted into "supra-natural communication of knowledge"; it is hard to save the word (and many others) from this state of corruption into which it has been brought by both supra-naturalism and naturalism. Nevertheless, "revelation" points to something for which no other adequate word is available—certainly not "religious experience." Revelation is the manifestation of the ultimate ground and meaning of human existence (and implicitly of all existence). It is not a matter of objective knowledge, of empirical research or rational inference. It is a matter of ultimate concern; it grasps the total personality and is effective through a set of symbols. Revelation is not restricted to a special period of history, to special personalities or writings. It occurs wherever it "wills." But we can speak of it only if it has become revelation *for us*, if we have ex-

perienced it existentially. Not experience, but revelation received *in* experience, gives the content of every theology.

There is, however, one point (which is only a point, without length or breadth) in which medium and content are identical, because in this point subject and object are identical: It is the awareness of the ultimate itself, the *esse ipsum*, which transcends the difference between subject and object and lies, as the presupposition of all doubts, beyond doubt; it is the *veritas ipsa*, as Augustine has called it. It is wrong to call this point "God" (as the ontological argument does), but it is necessary to call it "that in us which makes it impossible for us to escape God." It is the presence of the element of "ultimacy" in the structure of our existence, the basis of religious experience. It has been called "religious *apriori*"; but if we use this phrase (in the sense of *anima naturaliter religiosa*), we must remove every content from it and reduce it to the pure potentiality of having experiences with the character of "ultimate concern." Every content of such an experience is dependent on revelation, namely, on the special way, form, and situation in which this potentiality is actualized by a concern which is concrete and ultimate at the same time. While the certainty of the pure ultimacy is ultimate, conditioned by nothing, its concrete embodiment in symbols and acts is a matter of destiny and venturing faith. Whenever we speak of religious experience, it is important to distinguish these (inseparable) elements: (1) the "point" of immediate awareness of the unconditional which *is* empty but unconditionally certain; and (2) the "breadth" of a concrete concern which is full of content but has the conditional certainty of venturing faith. Theology deals with the

second element, while presupposing the first and measuring every theological statement by the standard of the ultimacy of the ultimate concern.

VI. THE ELEMENT OF RATIONALITY IN THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD

Theology is the rational "word" about God; it is the methodical interpretation of our ultimate concern. The rational element is not a source of theology. It does not give the content. But it gives the form; and the relation between form and content is extremely complex and demands careful analysis.

Theology is often identified with systematic theology. Although this terminology is bad, because it excludes historical and practical theology from their full part in the whole world of theology, it indicates that theology is essentially systematic. The word "system" has a narrower and a larger meaning. In its narrower sense the word points to the ideal of a deductive method in which a whole of interdependent presuppositions is derived from highest principles. Attempts have been made to develop such a system in the history of Christian thought. But the positive element in theology utterly resists a "system" in this sense; it includes openness and undermines a closed system. But "system" has also a larger sense. It designates a whole of propositions which are consistent, interdependent, and developed according to a definite method. In this sense all classical theology was systematic, and no theology, however fragmentary its actual work may be, can surrender the systematic idea. Every meaningful fragment is an implicit system, as every system is an explicit fragment; for man, and especially the theologian, lives in fragments, in reality as well as in thought.

It is obvious that the positive character of theology excludes a rational or natural theology, if these terms mean that, without existential participation in an ultimate concern, a detached analysis of reality can produce theological propositions. Even the rational substructure on which, according to scholasticism, the revealed superstructure is built, has convincing power only in the situation of faith. Even if (with Thomas and against Duns Scotus) the logical necessity and correctness of the arguments of natural theology are acknowledged, their existential significance without revelation is not asserted.

The terms "natural religion" or "natural revelation" or "natural theology" are extremely misleading. If religion is the state of being grasped by an ultimate concern, "natural religion" can only mean that the ultimate concern is experienced in an encounter with nature. This, of course, is not only possible and real, but it is a necessary part of every ultimate concern; but it cannot be separated from other elements which also belong to every ultimate concern, such as personal and social elements. The concepts "natural revelation" and "natural theology" are often used for a knowledge of God which is inferentially derived from the structure of reality. But, whether such conclusions are valid or not, in neither case have they the character of "revelation," and they should not be called "theological," for there is no meaningful speaking of God if he is taken as an object which is not, at the same time, the ground of the speaking about him. There is no meaningful speaking of God except in an existential attitude or in the situation of revelation. In any other attitude the religious word "God" is used after it has been deprived of its genuine, namely, its religious, meaning. So we can say: There *is* revela-

tion through nature; but there is no natural (rational) revelation. And there *is* theology dealing with nature; but there is no natural theology. Reason elaborates but does not produce theological propositions.

But the question arises as to whether the "elaboration" of the positive element in theology does not introduce a rational element into the substance itself. The urgency of this question is obvious when we look at the large number of philosophical concepts which have been used for theological purposes throughout the whole history of Christian thought.

It is possible to make a distinction between two types of theology, the *kerygmatic* and the *apologetic* type. In the kerygmatic type the kerygma—the message—is reproduced, interpreted, and organized either in predominantly biblical terms or in terms taken from the classical tradition. In the apologetic type the kerygma is related to the pre-philosophical and the philosophical interpretations of reality. An apology "makes answer"—answers the questions asked of, and the criticisms directed against, a concrete religion. But an answer is possible only if there is a common ground between the one who asks and the one who answers. Apologetic theology presupposes the idea of a universal revelation, to which reference can be made because it is acknowledged by both sides. Here the rational element in theological method becomes most important and most intimately connected with the positive element. The way in which this connection has been and should be carried through can be called the "method of correlation."

VII. THE METHOD OF CORRELATION

Wherever theology is understood in "existential" terms, all theological state-

ments have the character of "correlation." Luther has expressed this principle very often and very strongly: "As you believe, so you have." This does not mean that the belief produces its contents; such an idea would have been utterly blasphemous for Luther. But it does mean that the objective and the subjective side of faith are interrelated, for faith is the expression of the impact of an ultimate concern on the human personality; it is the expression of an "existential situation" and not the acceptance of an objective assertion. Therefore, it is always subjective and objective in a strict interdependence. It is the beginning of a process of disintegration in theology if the objective side is isolated as a quasi-scientific assertion and the subjective side as an emotional "will to believe" in spite of a lack of evidence. The problem of truth in theology cannot be solved in terms of objective evidence. It can be solved only in terms of existential criteria. In the prophetic, as well as in the mystical, literature one criterion always appears: The unconditional character of the unconditional. Symbolically, it is called the "majesty of God"; or his exclusiveness against all finite claims (idols) or the unconditional dependence of every power on the divine power; or the "justification by grace alone." Every genuine heresy is an attack on the divinity of the divine. It gives to something finite infinite validity. It conditions the unconditional, for instance, by human morality or rationality. The "truth" of the Reformation theology against the canons of the Council of Trent is its emphasis on the ultimacy of the ultimate concern; it is not a "scientific" superiority of the Protestant over the Catholic propositions. It is an "existential," not an "objective," truth. This is the reason why the struggle of theologians is signifi-

cant. They discuss, at least in principle, questions of "to be or not to be."

The method of correlation is especially the method of apologetic theology. Question and answer must be correlated in such a way that the religious symbol is interpreted as the adequate answer to a question, implied in man's existence, and asked in primitive, pre-philosophical, or elaborated philosophical terms. For instance, the question implied in human finitude is answered in the symbols which constitute the idea of God; or the symbol of revelation answers the questions which drive reason to its own boundary; or the question implied in man's existential disruption and despair is answered in the symbol of the Christ and his appearance under the conditions of existence; or the idea of the divine Spirit is interpreted as the answer to the question implied in the tragic ambiguities of life, especially man's spiritual life; or the problems of the meaning of history are answered in the symbol of the Kingdom of God. In all these cases the method of correlation establishes a mutual interdependence between questions and answers. The questions implied in human existence determine the meaning and the theological interpretation of the answers as they appear in the classical religious concepts. The form of the questions, whether primitive or philosophical, is decisive for the theological form in which the answer is given. And, conversely, the substance of the question is determined by the substance of the answer. Nobody is able to ask questions concerning God, revelation, Christ, etc., who has not already received some answer. So we can say: With respect to man's ultimate concern the questions contain the substance of the answers, and the answers are shaped by the form of the questions. Here the rational element in theological method has a de-

termining influence on theological propositions—not on their substance but on their form. But there is no way of saying a priori how much substance is hidden in the form. This can be said only in the process of theological work, and never fully. The reception of the “new reality,” is always conditioned by the “old reality,” which is conquered and fulfilled by it. This is the reason why early Christianity formulated the doctrine of the Logos, who has appeared in a unique way in Jesus as the Christ and is, at the same time, the universal principle of revelation in religion and culture. In this way the old reality can be considered as preparation for the new one; and the philosophical form is ultimately related to the substance of the theological answer instead of being alien to it. It seems to me that, without some form of a Logos doctrine (even if the term “Logos” is not used), no theology—certainly no apologetic theology—is possible.

A few examples may suffice to give a concrete impression of the method of correlation. If the question implied in human finitude is the question of God and the idea of God is the answer to this question, then modern existential analysis of human finitude becomes extremely valuable for the theological treatment of the idea of God. God becomes the correlate to human anxiety and contingency. He becomes the symbol of a “transcendent courage,” in which the characteristics of finitude, as essential insecurity, loneliness, having to die, etc., are overcome. In this way the idea of God receives existential significance. The meaningless and self-contradictory question about the “existence of God” is replaced by an intensely meaningful question concerning our participation in an infinite communion, security, power, and meaning in the divine life.

In the same way the question implied in the self-destructive trends of man's personal and social life is to be understood as the question to which the central Christian statement that Jesus is the Christ gives the answer. If Christology is treated on the basis of this correlation, it interprets the picture of Jesus Christ as the ultimate manifestation of saving power in life and history, as the appearance of a “new reality,” a power of wholeness and reconciliation conquering the “demonic” mechanisms in personal and social existence. Then our recent rediscovery of the contradictory structures in soul and community determines the form of our christological answer and makes this answer existential for our time. The method of correlation liberates Christology from a historicism which tries to base the Christian faith in the new reality on doubtful historical probabilities, and it also liberates Christology from the “alchemy” of the doctrine of two natures, interpreting its meaning as a statement of the paradox of the victorious maintenance of the divine-human unity in a personal life against all the disruptive attacks of man's existential situation.

The method of correlation, as these examples show, is at no point forced into the vicious debate between naturalism and supra-naturalism. It describes things as they show themselves to the religious consciousness in the light of the human situation, the questions implied in it, and the answers given to it by the Christian message. Theology has rediscovered its correlative and existential character. It has overcome a theology of objective statements and subjective emotions. It has become again a way of giving answers to the questions which are our ultimate concern.